

US Enterprise Hardware and Networking

UBS Evidence Lab inside: Consumer PC survey suggests memory weighing on demand

Equities

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Trimming CY27 PC units as elevated memory costs impact demand

UBS Evidence Lab surveyed 1,500 consumers in the US and China ([> Access Dataset](#)) to analyze PC purchase intent trends. In conjunction with the survey data and checks with Taiwanese ODMs, we trim our H2:CY26 PC unit / growth forecast and lower CY27 units given the lower base. For CY26 and CY27, we estimate PC units (ex-Chromebook) of 223.8M (-10.8% YoY) and 216.3M (-3.3% YoY) respectively vs our prior 224.9M (-10.4% YoY) and 228.6M (+1.6% YoY), respectively. We note that our Dell and HP forecasts reflect below seasonal unit demand in the second half of CY26 due to memory-related pull-ins and softness in the first half of CY27. According to the latest consumer survey, the four key takeaways that support our forecast are as follows:

- **Apple remains the most favored brand.** Apple remains the most popular brand globally with the US at ~27% despite declining ~100 bps sequentially and China increasing from ~13% to ~16%.
- **Memory costs a headwind:** Among respondents slowing a planned PC purchase, ~50% cited higher memory prices making PCs more expensive, up from ~37% in our last survey and ahead of broader household budget pressure at ~38% and recent upgrades at ~34%.
- **Consumer PC budgets in the US are increasing:** In the US, roughly 63% of respondents noted they are likely to spend more on their next PC, up from ~60% six months ago while ~51% consumers in China expect to pay more, roughly stable with 52% of respondents six months ago.
- **PC installed base is the youngest in three years:** Roughly 61% of respondents in the US noted they purchased their current PC in the past two years, up slightly from ~60% a year ago and the highest reading since Feb 2023 (65%) that benefitted from COVID-related demand. In China, ~66% of respondents noted they purchased their PC in the past two years, up from ~63% a year ago. Relatively recent purchases suggest consumer demand in CY27 is likely to be muted.

We lower our CY27 total PC unit estimates

PC shipment growth deteriorated from +5.5% YoY in Q126, supported by pull-ins, to -2.5% in Q226, with sequential growth of only 1% below normal seasonality. ODM feedback at UBS Taiwan Summit and recent monthly sales point to a further slowdown and additional OEM order cuts in 3Q26. Memory prices are increasingly a headwind with DRAM contract prices up 766% and NAND prices up 471% since mid-2025. Due to memory costs likely to persist at high levels and CPU makers also pushing through double digit price increases through the year, we expect a soft PC unit outlook next year also alongside more modest price hikes. Our CY26 forecast is relatively unchanged at 241.6M units, down 11% but we lower CY27 from 2% growth to a 4% decline as persistent memory inflation and double-digit CPU price increases weigh on affordability. ASP growth should partly offset the volume decline, leaving CY27 industry revenue up 2% to US\$205B versus our prior US\$210B forecast.

Figure 1: We forecast PC units (ex-chromebook) of 223.8M (-10.8% YoY) and 216.3M (-3.3% YoY), respectively

	Quarterly Trends				New Estimates			Original Estimates			% Chg. in UBS Est.		
	Q126	Q226	Q326E	Q426E	2025	2026E	2027E	2025E	2026E	2027E	2025E	2026E	2027E
Desktops	15.8	15.9	14.6	14.2	68.3	60.5	58.8	68.3	59.6	60.4	0.0%	1.5%	-2.6%
YoY growth	2.8%	-3.0%	-17.8%	-24.5%	11.8%	-11.4%	-2.7%	11.8%	-12.7%	1.3%			
Notebooks	42.9	42.6	39.1	38.6	182.6	163.3	157.5	182.6	165.3	168.2	0.0%	-1.2%	-6.4%
YoY growth	8.1%	-1.7%	-21.9%	-21.9%	8.7%	-10.6%	-3.6%	8.7%	-9.5%	1.7%			
Chromebooks	4.9	5.8	3.7	2.9	19.9	17.2	14.7	19.9	16.7	18.1	0.0%	3.4%	-18.5%
YoY growth	-6.7%	-6.4%	-15.8%	-30.0%	8.8%	-13.4%	-14.6%	8.8%	-16.2%	8.3%			
Total PCs (exc. Chrome)	58.7	58.5	53.8	52.8	250.9	223.8	216.3	250.9	224.9	228.6	0.0%	-0.5%	-5.3%
QoQ growth	-13.9%	-0.4%	-8.1%	-1.8%									
YoY growth	6.6%	-2.1%	-20.8%	-22.6%	9.5%	-10.8%	-3.3%	9.5%	-10.4%	1.6%			
Commercial PC units	42.4	42.2	37.6	36.4	177.0	158.6	153.8	177.0	159.8	162.2	0.0%	-0.7%	-5.2%
YoY growth	4.5%	-3.1%	-18.4%	-22.3%	10.3%	-10.4%	-3.0%	10.3%	-9.8%	1.6%			
Consumer PC units	21.3	22.1	19.9	19.2	93.8	82.5	77.3	93.8	81.9	84.4	0.0%	0.7%	-8.4%
YoY growth	7.3%	-1.2%	-24.1%	-24.4%	7.9%	-12.1%	-6.3%	7.9%	-12.7%	3.1%			
Total PC units	63.6	64.3	57.4	55.7	270.8	241.0	231.1	270.8	241.6	246.6	0.0%	-0.2%	-6.3%
QoQ growth	-12.0%	1.0%	-10.7%	-3.1%									
YoY growth	5.5%	-2.5%	-20.5%	-23.0%	9.4%	-11.0%	-4.1%	9.4%	-10.8%	2.1%			

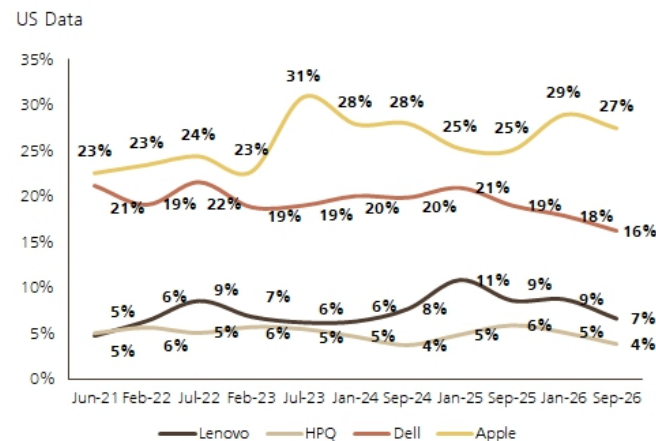
Source: Gartner and UBS estimates

Apple remains the most preferred brand in the US and rises in China

The survey asked participants regarding the brand of PC they are most likely to buy. In the US, Apple remains the most preferred brand (~27%) despite declining ~100 bps sequentially. Similarly, Dell (~16%), Lenovo (~7%), and HP (~4%) all declined sequentially.

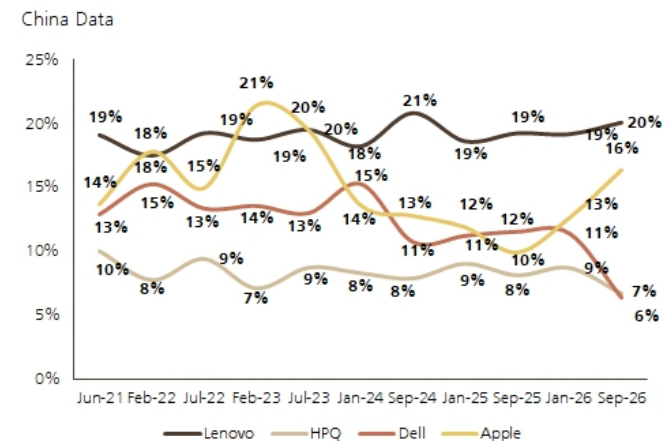
In China, preference for Apple (~16%) notably rose ~300 bps sequentially as HP (~7%) and Dell (~6%) declined ~200 bps and ~500 bps, respectively. Lenovo rose ~100 bps sequentially to ~20%, roughly consistent with responses over the last five surveys.

Figure 2: In the US, Apple continues to remain the most preferred brand



Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([Access Dataset](#))

Figure 3: In China, preference for HP and Dell declined as Apple rose



Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([Access Dataset](#))

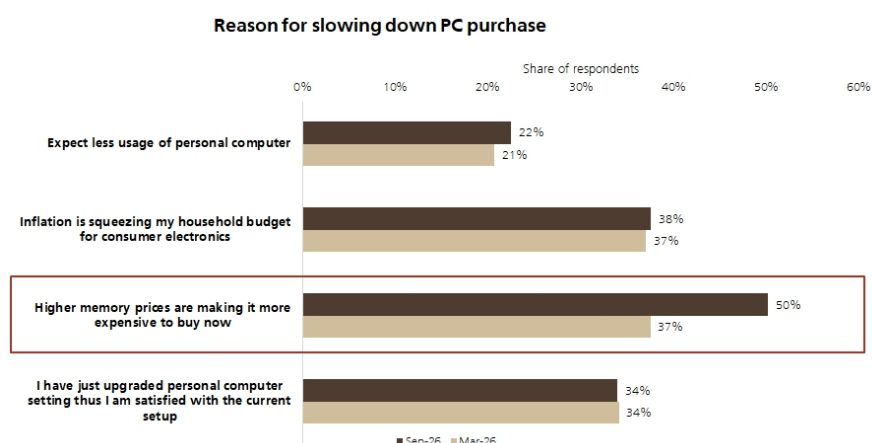
Survey suggests higher memory costs weighing on consumer purchases

As noted earlier, we estimate that DRAM and NAND costs are up 766% and 471%, respectively, since mid-2025, leading many PC vendors to raise prices on devices. As such, we asked respondents regarding memory's impact on their PC purchasing decisions. The three key takeaways in our view:

1. Approximately 50% of respondents (+1,300 bps sequentially) cited higher memory prices as a reason to slow down their PC purchase.
2. High memory and component prices were a reason for ~19% of respondents to not purchase a PC.
3. Notably, ~48% of total respondents (+300 bps sequentially) noted that they

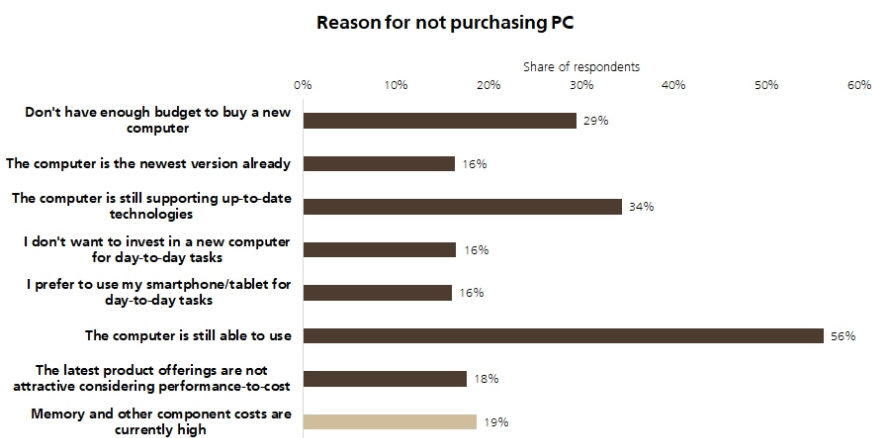
would purchase a PC with the same memory/specs but at a higher price vs ~19% (~600 bps sequentially) opting to delay their purchase until memory prices decline.

Figure 4: Memory is becoming a larger obstacle for consumer PC purchases



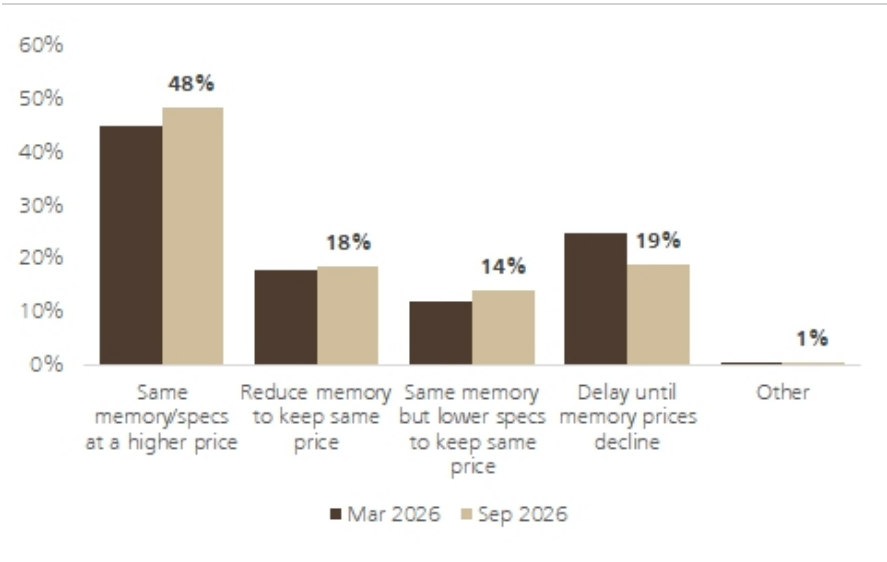
Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([Access Dataset](#))

Figure 5: Roughly 19% of respondents believe high memory and component prices are a reason to not purchase a PC



Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([Access Dataset](#))

Figure 6: Roughly 1 in 5 respondents would delay their PC purchase until memory prices decline



Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([> Access Dataset](#))

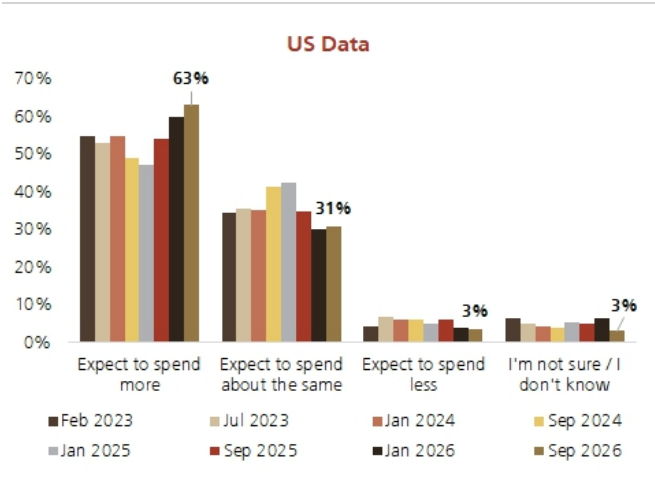
Consumers in the US expect to spend more on their next PC

Respondents expecting to spend more on their next PC rose ~300 bps to ~63%, a survey high, likely reflecting the higher component cost dynamic, in our view. Notably, the average PC purchase budget in the US was relatively unchanged at ~\$825 despite the higher price expectations.

Budgets in China tick higher sequentially

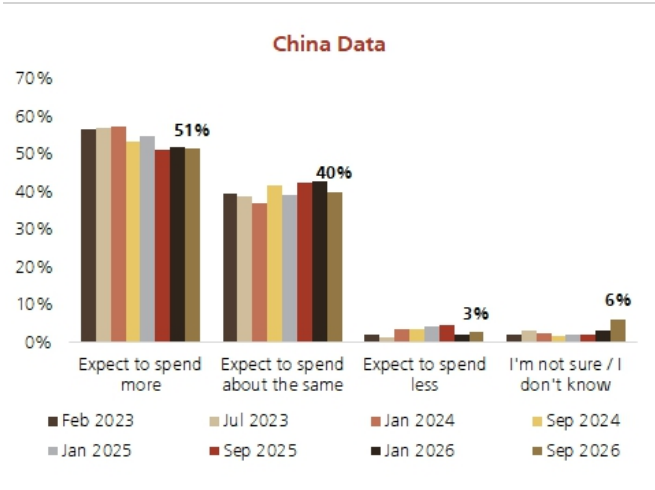
Respondents expecting to spend more on their next PC ticked was roughly unchanged at ~51% (-100 bps sequentially), as those expecting to spend about the same declined ~300 bps to ~40%. The average PC budget in China ticked higher by ~3% sequentially to 7,954 RMB, reflecting roughly half of the respondents expecting higher prices in our view.

Figure 7: Roughly 63% of US respondents expect to spend more on their next PC



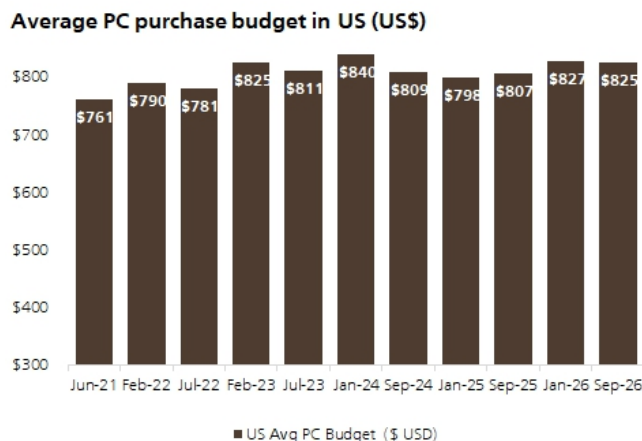
Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([> Access Dataset](#))

Figure 8: About half of respondents in China expect to pay more for their next PC



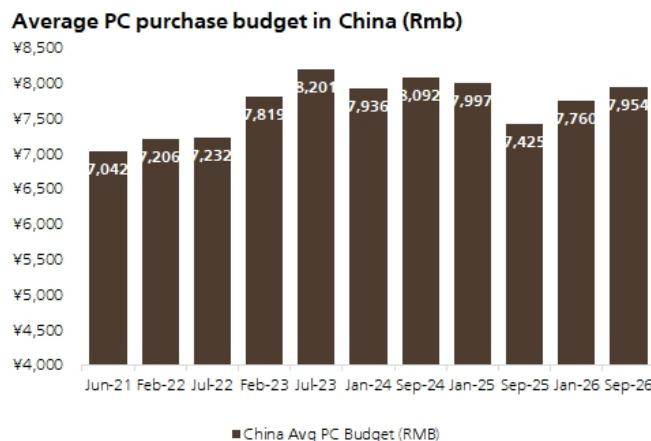
Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([> Access Dataset](#))

Figure 9: US budgets were relatively unchanged sequentially, a surprise in our view



Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([Access Dataset](#))

Figure 10: China budgets ticked higher by roughly 3% sequentially



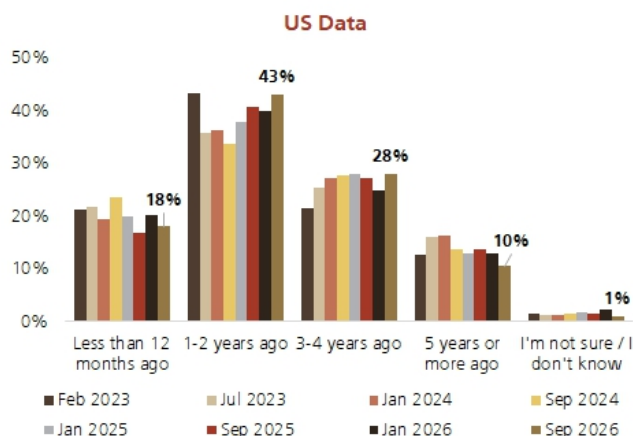
Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([Access Dataset](#))

Consumer PC replacement cycle just below 3 years

We asked respondents regarding when they bought their current PC, how often they buy a new one, and when they think they will purchase a new device. The three key takeaways:

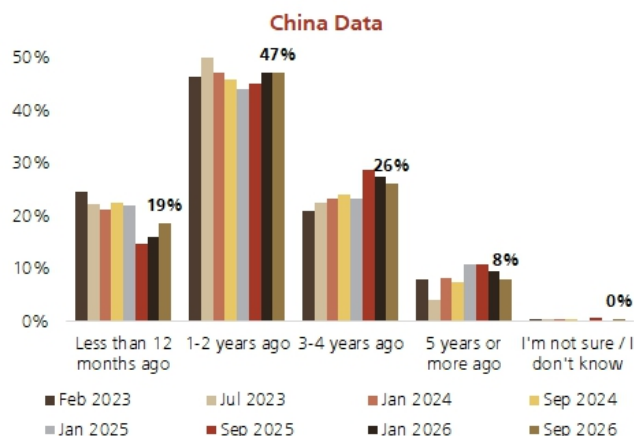
1. Roughly 61% and 66% of respondents in the US and China purchased their PC in the past two years, respectively, up ~100 bps and ~300 bps sequentially.
2. The average consumer replacement cycle is ~2.8 years and ~2.9 years in the US and China, respectively, the lowest mark in roughly three years.
3. Roughly 72% and 71% of respondents in the US and China expect to purchase a new PC in the next two years, up ~400 bps and ~300 bps sequentially.

Figure 11: US - When did you buy your current Laptop/Desktop?



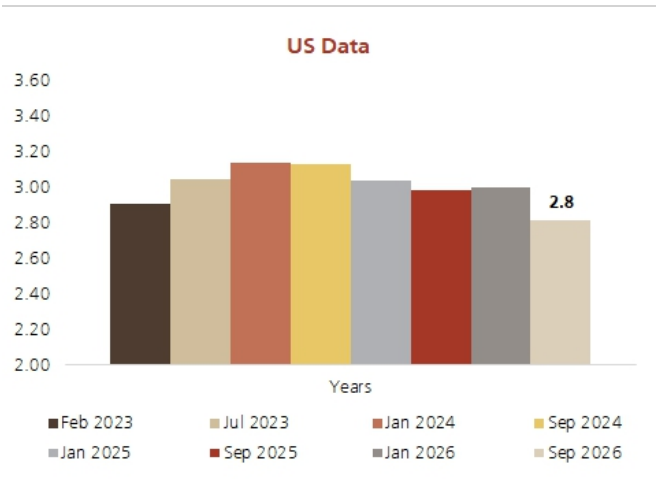
Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([Access Dataset](#))

Figure 12: China - When did you buy your current Laptop/Desktop?



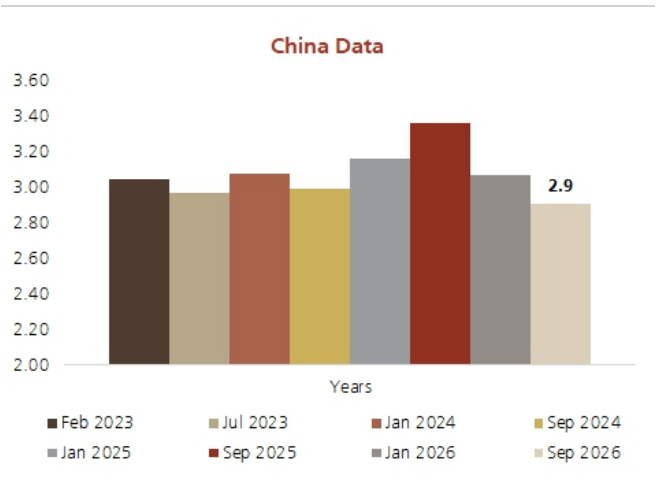
Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([Access Dataset](#))

Figure 13: US - How often do you normally buy a new Laptop/Desktop (years)?



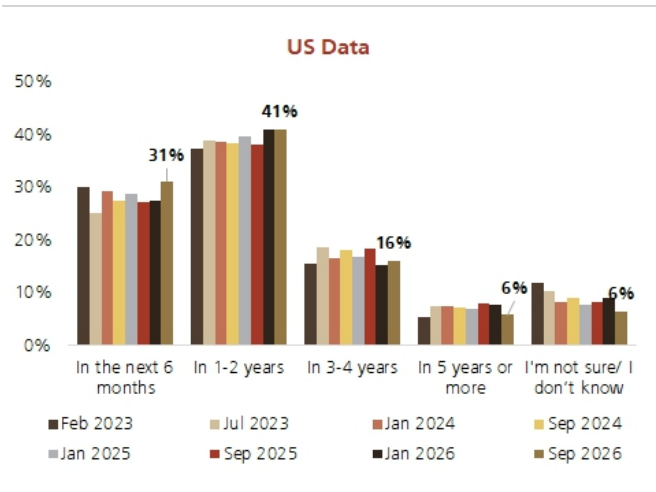
Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([Access Dataset](#))

Figure 14: China - How often do you normally buy a new Laptop/Desktop (years)?



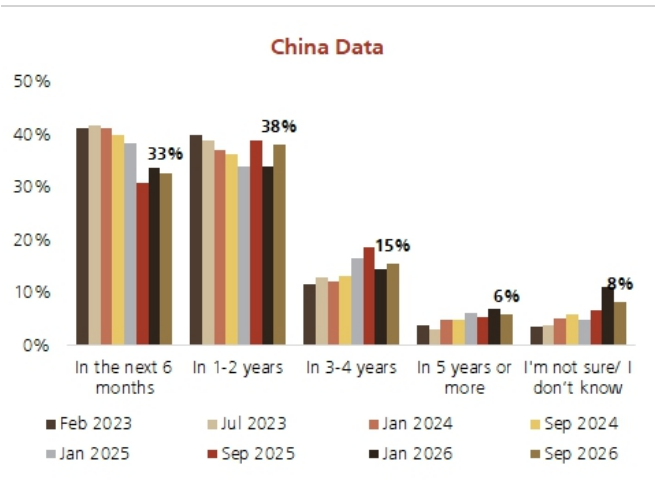
Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([Access Dataset](#))

Figure 15: US - When do you think you will buy a new computer?



Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([Access Dataset](#))

Figure 16: China - When do you think you will buy a new computer?



Source: UBS Evidence Lab ([Access Dataset](#))

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Global PC Purchase Intentions Consumer Survey ([Access Dataset](#))

This report leverages the following UBS Evidence Lab asset: Global PC Purchase Intentions Consumer Survey. This survey of consumers in the US and China provides a view on consumer awareness, usage and attitudes towards personal computers.

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Source: UBS. Rating allocations are as of 30 June 2026.

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Additional Prices: Dell Technologies, US\$568.06 (18 Sep 2026); HP Inc, US\$34.40 (18 Sep 2026); Source: UBS. All prices as of local market close.

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